High cost of beef unlikely to drop soon, experts say

Historically small cattle herds and big demand for protein part of reason, they say. **In Money**

Charlize Theron takes on wilds of Australia in 'Apex'

Rock climbing, kayaking and running all in a day's work for star of new survival thriller. **In Life**

Sweet 16: Battle of the contenders heats up

We rank the women's and men's teams as brackets narrow. **In Sports**

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UCONN'S AZZI FUDD BY GREGORY FISHER/IMAGN IMAGES; DUKE'S CAMERON BOOZER BY JARED C. TILTON/GETTY IMAGES

USA TODAY

THE NATION'S NEWS | $3 | THURSDAY, MARCH 26, 2026

Farmer Vicente Garrido checks the damage caused by a bomb dropped by the Ecuadoran army in San Martin, Ecuador, along the Colombian border. LUIS ACOSTA/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Target of Ecuador, U.S. attack disputed

Farmers, not traffickers, were bombed, locals say

Eduardo Cuevas and Boris Q'va
USA TODAY

A joint American and Ecuadoran military operation bombed farms and homes in an Amazon village in Ecuador, according to residents and their lawyers.

Ecuador's defense ministry on March 6 said Operation Total Extermination included aerial bombardment in the province of Sucumbios, which sits in the country's northeastern corner, on the border with Colombia. Ecuadoran officials said the operation, conducted with U.S. intelligence, destroyed a hideout for a Colombian drug trafficking group.

> **"Under the government's banner of fighting crime and drug trafficking, human rights are being violated."**
>
> **Maria Espinosa**
> Alliance of Organizations for Human Rights

Residents of San Martin, the farming village of about 27 families in Sucumbios, told USA TODAY that the operation, which took place March 1-6, didn't target drug traffickers. Instead, they said military personnel destroyed farms. Detained local workers have told a United Nations human rights group that Ecuadoran soldiers tortured them.

"The government's version is that they bombed encampments of certain armed groups," Vicente Garrido, vice president of the community of San Martin, who has lived there for nearly 40 years, said in an interview. "But what we're showing the world is that these aren't encampments, these are peasants' homes."

American military personnel said the operation showed the success of the partnership with Ecuador, whose conservative government has emerged as a key ally of the Trump administration in Latin America.

Kingsley Wilson, a spokesperson for the U.S. Department of War,

See ECUADOR, Page 6A

Generation Z and the demise of the house party

Many missed out and now long for the rite of passage others had

GETTY IMAGES

Charles Trepany USA TODAY

We used to be a proper country. Where dancing on sticky living room floors, sneaking beers from our parents' refrigerators and bumping music on stereos were hallmarks of adolescence. • Gen Z, apparently, doesn't know that. Or at least not to the same degree millennials and Gen X-ers do. • On social media, some members of Generation Z – the cohort born between 1997 and 2012 – have confessed they never went to large house parties as teenagers, to the shock and horror of older Gen Zers, millennials and Gen Xers, who remember them fondly. • In one Reddit post, a Gen Zer innocently dared to ask if the ragers depicted in teen movies from the 1980s through the early 2000s were ever actually real. According to thousands of millennials and Gen Xers in the replies: Yes, sweet summer child. They certainly were.

See HOUSE PARTIES, Page 3A

High court deals blow to music industry

Internet providers aren't liable for user piracy

Maureen Groppe
USA TODAY

WASHINGTON – The Supreme Court on March 25 ruled against the music industry's effort to punish internet service providers that allow users to illegally copy and share content.

The justices said a lower court erred when it found Cox Communications liable for steep damages after it continued to provide internet service to customers who had been flagged repeatedly for piracy.

"Cox did not tailor its service to make copyright infringement easier," Justice Clarence Thomas wrote in the unanimous decision. "Cox simply provided Internet access, which is used for many purposes other than copyright infringement."

Music companies and publishers had sued Cox Communications, saying it helped users rob them of billions of dollars a year. KEVIN DIETSCH/GETTY IMAGES

Cox argued the standard used by the lower court would leave providers no choice but to cut off internet access to large account holders such as universities, hospitals and even entire towns to avoid massive judgments.

But Sony Music Entertainment and a host of other leading recording companies and music publishers said Cox helped 60,000 customers distribute more than 10,000 copyrighted works for free, contributing to a problem that robs the industry of billions of dollars every year.

Cox, one of the nation's largest internet service providers, asked the Supreme Court to intervene after a jury in Virginia decided that the company owed $1 billion in damages to the music industry.

An appeals court threw out the damages and ordered a new trial based on reduced violations.

See PIRACY, Page 6A

TSA workers are 'drowning' in debt, stress, union says

Trevor Hughes
USA TODAY

DENVER – Day after day, flight after flight: Cancun. Orlando. Honolulu. Happy families and college students heading off on spring break vacations are being helped every day by 61,000 unpaid TSA workers.

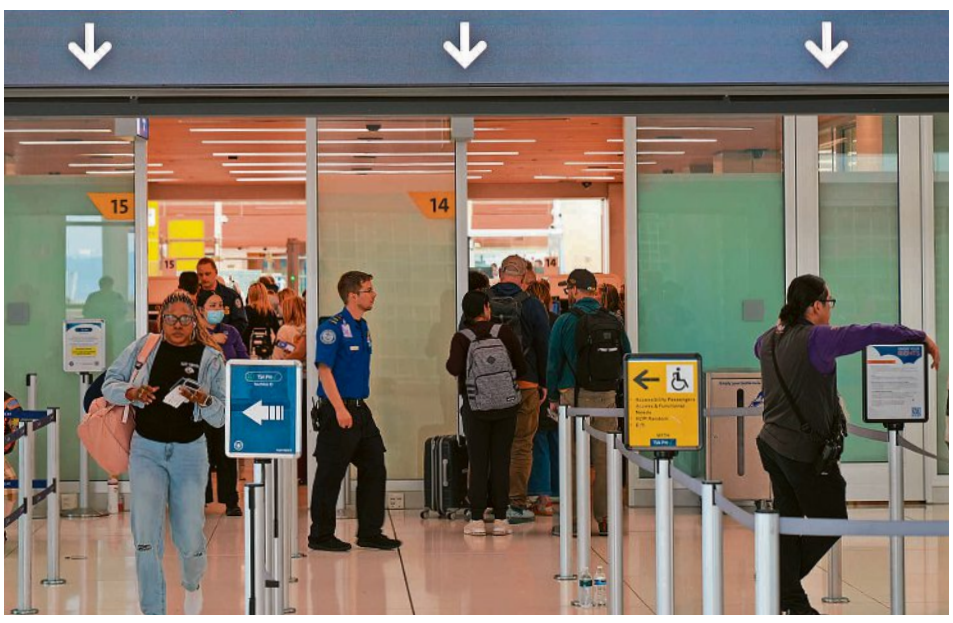
The screeners reminding travelers to remove liquids from their carry-ons? Unpaid.

Those scanning suitcases for guns and knives? Unpaid.

Those comparing IDs to prevent terrorists from boarding? Unpaid.

"We're basically invisible, and we can't let you see that our guard is

See TSA, Page 3A



TSA employees at Denver International and at major airports across the country have been working without pay for weeks. TREVOR HUGHES/USA TODAY

What would it take for ICE to take on TSA duties?

How the agencies' mission, training, skills and culture are different. **3A**

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